

High court receptive to tax-funded faith school

Case could allow the first public religious charter — and reshape education

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL, ANN E. MARIMOW AND LAURA MECKLER

A divided Supreme Court on Wednesday appeared open to allowing the creation of the nation's first public religious charter school in Oklahoma, a blockbuster move that could reshape American education and redraw the boundary between church and state.

A ruling for St. Isidore of Seville Catholic Virtual School would for the first time allow direct and complete taxpayer funding to establish a faith-based school, sanctioning government sponsorship of a curriculum that calls for students to adhere to Catholic beliefs and the church's religious mission.

It would be a giant new step for the court's conservative majority in boosting the role of religion in public life, building on a series of rulings over the last decade affecting schools, the workplace and the display of faith-based symbols on public property.

The change could have vast — and unpredictable — implications for parochial, charter and traditional public schools. It would almost certainly spark efforts to create similar schools in other states or convert existing religious private schools into public charters. But a ruling for St. Isidore also could prompt states that don't want to fund religious education to tighten

SEE SCHOOLS ON A8

Religious charters: Once thought far-fetched, now nearing reality. **A8**

U.S., Ukraine sign draft of long-debated minerals deal

BY SIOBHÁN O'GRADY AND JEFF STEIN

KYIV — The United States and Ukraine have signed a deal to establish joint investment in Ukraine's mineral wealth, oil, gas and other natural resources, officials said Wednesday, in a move that would fulfill a key White House request and give Kyiv a degree of much-desired U.S. backing.

"As the President has said, the United States is committed to helping facilitate the end of this cruel and senseless war," Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said. "This agreement signals clearly to Russia that the Trump Administration is committed to a peace process centered on a free, sovereign, and prosperous Ukraine over the long term."

The deal will establish the "United States-Ukraine Reconstruction Investment Fund," which will allow the "two countries to work collaboratively and invest together to ensure that our mutual assets, talents, and capabilities can accelerate Ukraine's economic recovery," Bessent said in a statement.

Yulia Svyrydenko, Ukraine's

SEE UKRAINE ON A13

South Africa: Trump's feud could hinder a key minerals project. **A13**



JUSTIN SULLIVAN/GETTY IMAGES

Trucks line up to enter a shipping berth at the Port of Oakland in California this week as freight containers tower in the background.

Trump urges patience, shifts blame after weak report

BY MATT VISER AND THEODORIC MEYER

President Donald Trump lashed out Wednesday morning at increasingly dim economic forecasts that have cast his policies in a harsh light and clouded what he had hoped would be a valedictory marker of his 100 days in office.

He has blamed the Federal Reserve. He has expressed anger at what he has described as unfair trade policies of the past, and bluntly said that Americans may have to stomach paying more and getting less. And, more than anything, he has blamed his predecessor.

"You probably saw some numbers today," he said at the start of a Cabinet meeting at the White House. "And I have to start off by saying, that's Biden; that's not Trump."

It was an echo of a social media post a few hours earlier — "This is Biden's Stock Market,

not Trump's," he wrote — even though the financial falloff has occurred since he took office and Trump on the eve of his inauguration had pointed to a stock market that had "surged" and called it "the Trump effect."

"I'm not taking credit or dis-credit for the stock market," he said, when asked about the hypocrisy of claiming credit for good news and casting blame for bad. "I'm just saying that we inherited a mess."

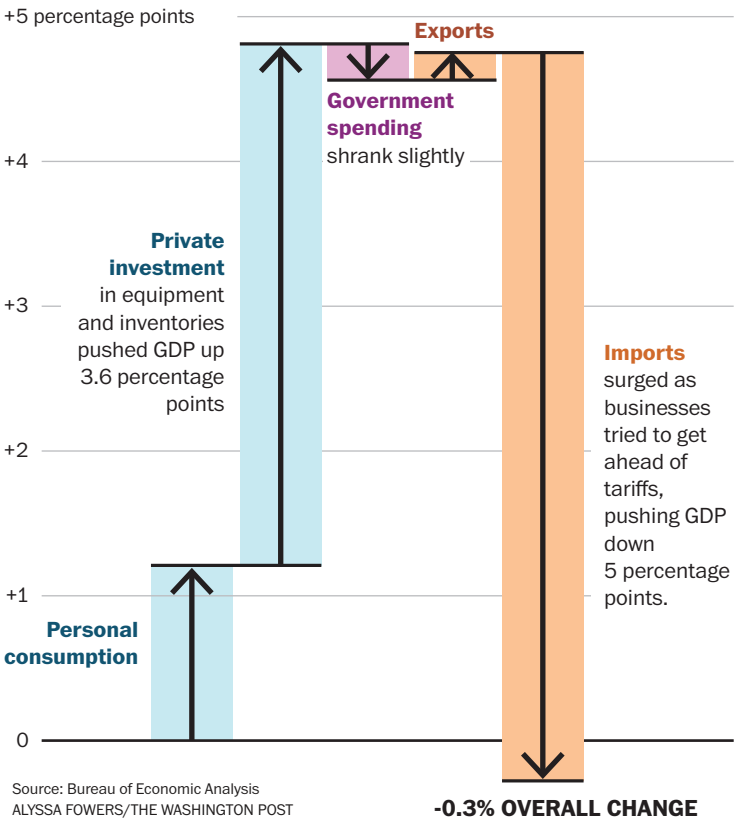
His social media post concluded with a message to Americans about the economic policies he has implemented that have rocked the domestic and global economies: "BE PATIENT!!!" And during a Cabinet meeting, he suggested that American consumers may have to adapt.

"Somebody said, 'Oh the

SEE ECONOMY ON A16

The Fed: President renews his attacks on the central bank. **A16**

Contributions to quarterly GDP change in Q1 2025



Tariffs sapping economy already

U.S. GDP DECLINES IN FIRST QUARTER

Imports surge as firms move up their purchases

BY ABHA BHATTARAI

The U.S. economy shrank in the first three months of 2025, contracting by an annualized rate of 0.3 percent — a stark reversal after nearly three years of solid growth, as tariff-related uncertainty upended spending patterns and raised fears of an impending recession.

The new report on gross domestic product, released by the Bureau of Economic Analysis on Wednesday, showed the first deceleration of the U.S. economy since the pandemic-fueled supply chain woes of early 2022.

This economic slowdown came primarily from a dramatic increase in imports — which count against GDP — as businesses rushed to purchase foreign goods ahead of President Donald Trump's promised tariffs.

A drop in government spending also weighed on growth, and separately, consumer spending slowed, especially compared with recent months, as Americans hit the brakes on large purchases.

"Growth has simply vanished," Chris Rupkey, chief economist at FwdBonds, a financial research firm, wrote in a note to clients after the report's release. "Maybe some of this negativity is due to a rush to bring in imports before the tariffs go up, but there is simply no way for policy advisers to sugar-coat this."

Financial markets initially recoiled at the news, with all three major indexes trading lower for much of Wednesday before paring back those losses later in the day. Still, it was a tough month for the stock market, with the Dow Jones Industrial Average losing more than 3 percent of its value and the S&P 500 down about 1 percent.

Trump dismissed the negative

SEE GDP ON A15

Hunger grips Gaza once again as siege nears two months

People are scraping by on one meal a day, if they eat at all, after brief truce crumbled in March



ABDEL KAREEM HANA/AP

Palestinians receive donated food Wednesday at a distribution center in Nuseirat, central Gaza Strip. The United Nations warned that the situation in the besieged enclave "is likely the worst it has been."

BY MIRIAM BERGER AND TIM CARMAN

JAFFA, ISRAEL — Israel's two-month siege of the Gaza Strip has again plunged the enclave into a hunger crisis, leaving shelves and aid stocks empty, residents and relief agencies say, and wiping out the humanitarian gains made during a brief ceasefire earlier this year.

No food, fuel, aid or commercial goods have entered Gaza since March 2, after the first phase of the truce expired. Israel said it was imposing the blockade to pressure Hamas, which rules the territory and attacked Israeli communities on Oct. 7, 2023. That assault killed around 1,200 people, with Hamas and other militants taking more than 250 others hostage.

Weeks into the siege — which is now the longest of the war — people are surviving on one meal a day, if they eat at all, Palestinians and aid workers say. The flour, milk, eggs and meat that were available during the cease-

SEE GAZA ON A12

Kennedy plans requirement for placebo use in vaccine tests

BY LAUREN WEBER, RACHEL ROUBEIN, LENA H. SUN AND CAROLYN Y. JOHNSON

Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. intends to shift the way vaccines are tested, a move that the agency said will increase transparency but that medical experts fear could limit access to vaccines and undermine the public's trust in immunization depending on its implementation.

The potential change outlined in a statement says all new vaccines will be required to undergo placebo testing, a procedure in which some people receive the vaccine and others receive an inert substance — such as a saline shot — before the results are compared.

"All new vaccines will undergo safety testing in placebo-controlled trials prior to licensure

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IN THE NEWS

Pentagon influence Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth's wife holds an unorthodox influence in agency decision-making, sources say. **A3**

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